

Episode 32: Once Upon a Time... (24) *Saint Seiya* Part 11 – Theatrical *Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth* – Completion and Setback

Hey!, *Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi* started October 7th at 6:30 AM on TV Asahi. Episode 1's viewership was 3.3%! Man, considering it's a 6:30 AM show, that's quite a number.

So for further viewership increases, I contacted and promoted to several friends with small children... but got sad reactions like "Let me sleep on Sunday mornings (cries)" and "Let me sleep at least until *PreCure* at 8:30 (angry)" (cries). Ah, everyone's having a tough time (bitter laugh).

Still, I want lots of families with small children to watch "*Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi*". Look, you don't have to get up - just record it! (laughs) From November 2nd, nationwide broadcast on BS Asahi starts too. That one's at 6 PM!

Everyone please support "*Hatarakids: Maiham-gumi*"!

Well then.

Though it's now normal to add colour direction to key animation for overseas animation/finishing orders, back then adding colour direction to in-between animation was still more common. Especially for theatrical works. "Since it's theatrical, we must make it carefully and properly." The studio was still full of that spirit. I was happy that internal tracing and painting staff especially had such feelings.

Toei Doga's internal staff, especially tracing staff, were remarkable in their technique. Staff who had handled all hand-trace works continuously. Though I naturally could do hand tracing as someone on the finishing fringe, man, I was nowhere near their level (laughs).

For cuts we wanted to finish especially carefully, we still sent them to internal painting then, but when requesting trace machine line corrections, particularly small detailed drawings would be redrawn by hand trace. Certainly trace machine lines weren't suited to small drawings and became thick, blurred, crushed lines overall.

But actually, I disliked this all-hand tracing (laughs). For copyright posters or large drawings needing colour trace lines it was naturally OK, but for small drawings it inevitably didn't match the original in-between animation lines. Subtle nose bridges or jaw lines - the lines became clean and beautiful, but still didn't capture the in-between animation line nuance. Rather, even somewhat faded or crushed, trace machine lines picked up drawing nuances as-is. Especially for works like *Saint Seiya*, image sharpness was the deciding factor.

Saying this would anger the tracing staff back then, but somehow it just didn't work for me, so I ended up issuing lots of tracing retakes. Ah, sorry (bitter laugh).

However, such care was possible during preview creation, the initial schedule period. Time gradually ran short while animation progressed slowly. Well, originally trying to handle a 70-minute theatrical work in 3-4 months was questionable itself. So cuts gradually switched to overseas animation/finishing orders.

Still, main story colour direction work was enjoyable. Especially the "rematches" between Seiya and other Bronze Saints and Gold Saints! Though each duration was short, I could handle battles I couldn't directly colour-direct during the TV series with new theatrical animation. Every time I held key animation or in-between animation and flipped through them, I was constantly excited. Facing good animation, key animation, or in-between animation, your spine goes "sharp" and your mind tightens. Such enjoyable tense days.

Around the same time, another company was producing a major theatrical work in full swing. "**AKIRA**". Since it was notable work industry-wide in various ways, various

stories about *AKIRA*'s production situation leaked into our staff room. Originally longer than *Saint Seiya*, it seemed quite difficult in various ways.

Hearing such stories, our situation was also getting quite tough. Well, only the director maintained his usual pace, sitting firmly.

However, I'd fallen into a bad situation myself. A summer cold I caught once at the end of June had cleared up and seemed to improve... but perhaps from accumulated fatigue from consecutive late-night work, coughing and fever continued afterward. Then in mid-July when main story colour direction work was almost finished, I crashed with fever exceeding 40°C. Diagnosis: "acute pneumonia." Yes, doctor's orders stopped me.

Ultimately I couldn't check final cel deliveries. Though I could attend final checking, the retake replacement work limit had already passed, leaving several disappointing retakes. The biggest failure cut among them was one made for previews. The cut where Saori-san's skirt colour was changed to blue somehow wasn't replaced when the master was assembled.

Thus ended the days of theatrical "***Saint Seiya: Legend of Crimson Youth***". After that, by company orders I had one month of forced rest. Perhaps due to my "criminal record" of crashing during theatrical production, I was removed from staff for the 4th theatrical *Saint Seiya* released the following spring, and TV series *Saint Seiya* also changed production systems, so for the 2nd season "Asgard Arc (アスガルド編)" and 3rd season "Poseidon Arc (ポセイドン編)," my work returned to only main-related character colour direction.

(Just between us, I'm not convinced about Athena (アテナ) in theatrical work #4. Athena would never cry like that, and you shouldn't make Athena cry like that. That's impossible (laughs))

Then TV series *Saint Seiya* ended. For the final episode, I think I watched the first screening with everyone in the screening room, but somehow I have no memory of the content. While watching this final episode of a work I'd had many personal feelings about, my mind probably went to memories of *Saint Seiya* so far. Years later, encountering that final episode in a CATV rerun, I remember being stunned thinking "Ah, so this is how it ended" (bitter laugh).

Then one day after over ten years had passed. A certain story reached me: "They're doing a sequel. *Hades Twelve Temples Arc* (ハーデス十二宮編) is decided."

(07.10.16)